

Europeans oppose combustion engine bans

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Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By JORDYN DAHL with TOMMASO LECCA SNEAK PEEK — Europeans back the shift to clea

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with TOMMASO LECCA

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SNEAK PEEK

— Europeans back the shift to clean technologies but they oppose banning combustion engine vehicles, according to a new poll.

— The aviation industry is pushing for competitiveness to be at the core of the next EU strategy for the sector and for mistakes made in the previous strategy to be avoided.

— Transport costs are on the rise as businesses turn to rail and freight to transport goods with low water levels leading to capacity limitations for shipping.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

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DRIVING THE DAY

POLL BACKS CLEAN ENERGY TRANSITION: With gasoline and diesel costs top of mind for European voters, they say the latest energy crisis caused by the war on Iran is more of a reason to accelerate the transition to clean energy, according to fresh polling from Public First shared with POLITICO.

Eighty-three percent say the war has already increased prices or expect it to do so. Asked how their country should respond, 50 percent favor greater investment in renewable energy, compared with 27 percent who want more European fossil fuels.

What it means for mobility: While respondents backed action on climate change and a host of energy policies — a ban on combustion engine cars was one of only two policies that saw clear opposition. Forty-six percent of those polled reject bans on gasoline and diesel vehicles, while only 27 percent back the idea.

Politicians sense the direction: That view is in line with growing political opposition to the EU's policy on combustion engine cars. The bloc has slightly watered down its 2035 ban on the sale of new CO2-emitting vehicles, but many political groupings — especially those on the right side of the spectrum — want the policy to be completely scrapped.

Parliament steps up: The European Parliament plans to hit the ground running after the summer holidays to reach a compromise on the Commission's proposed reform of the 2035 law.

Competing interests: The automotive sector has lobbied intensely for the emission standards to be weakened and for new combustion engine vehicles and hybrids to be sold long past 2035, arguing that doing away with the powertrains will undercut their competitive edge against Chinese EV-makers. A flood of cheaper battery-powered cars from China, coupled with high energy costs, has led to a surge in consumer interest in electric vehicles. For more on that, your anchor and Thorsten Mumme have the story on the growing blowback against EV subsidies that help Chinese carmakers.

A similar discussion is underway in the United Kingdom, as automakers are also pushing for the government to relax a low-emission mandate. New Prime Minister Andy Burnham has signaled he'll acquiesce to the demands by bringing forward a review of EV sales target for carmakers.

Buy European, up to a point: The poll also asked about recent 'Buy European' legislation — a big issue for the car industry. Voters support the idea of buying European by a margin of 53 percent to 18 percent, but not at any cost, writes our colleague Aude van den Hove. Half of respondents prefer clean technology made in Europe even if it is slower and more expensive, compared with 30 percent who would buy it more cheaply from China — a result that has implications for the car industry.

The debate: The poll lands as European policymakers fight over how much preferential treatment European-made clean tech should receive in the Industrial Accelerator Act the European Commission presented in March. The EU executive wants to shape demand for European products like electric vehicles by giving them an advantage in public procurement. EU countries have already proposed recasting the Commission's proposal, while the European Parliament has yet to agree on a common position.

A note on methodology: Public First surveyed more than 26,000 Europeans between May 21 and June 18 in 24 EU countries and the United Kingdom. No survey was conducted in Cyprus, Luxembourg and Malta.

AVIATION

AVIATION STRATEGY REVIVES INDUSTRY DEBATE: DG MOVE is working on the upcoming presentation of a new EU aviation and aeronautics strategy, which the Commission aims to present in the third quarter, although diplomats and lobbyists widely expect it to slip to October or November. The aviation industry has a long wish list and fresh concerns about the strategy.

Expectations vs. reality: The Commission's previous Aviation Strategy for Europe, unveiled in 2015, set out an ambitious reform agenda. Delivering it proved much harder. The strategy envisaged completing the Single European Sky reform by 2016, but the legislation was finalized only in December 2024. Reform of EU air passenger rights — also expected by 2016 — dragged on for years before negotiators finally reached a deal in June. Other initiatives were delayed or shelved, partly because of the Covid pandemic.

Ahead of the new strategy, the Commission collected feedback from 248 respondents. Companies and industry associations accounted for more than 57 percent of the submissions, with the remainder coming from NGOs, public authorities, researchers and citizens.

Past regrets: "The 2015 Aviation Strategy set the right agenda but led to the adoption of sizeable complex rules," said Neva Sadikoglu Novaky, head of the EU office of the International Air Transport

Association, the airline lobby.

"It also fell short in delivering real operational and competitive improvements that should have made European aviation a much stronger economic driver than it is today," she told Tommaso, noting that IATA "fully support[s] a review of the strategy."

Looking forward: "To succeed, the new strategy must have competitiveness at its core and be rooted in global standards," Sadikoglu Novaky added. "A successful strategy should balance ambition with reality, enabling sustainable connectivity growth in support of Europe's long-term prosperity," she said.

EES SUMMER CHAOS AVOIDED THANKS TO EU FLEXIBILITY: The EU's decision to let border authorities suspend the Entry Exit System's biometric data collection when overwhelmed by arriving passengers has prevented major disruption at Schengen entry points this summer, including at the bloc's busiest airports. Border officers at major hubs such as Paris Charles de Gaulle and Amsterdam Schiphol have frequently skipped fingerprint and facial image collection, as Tommaso reported during the Morning Mobility summer break.

Frankfurt and Amsterdam reportedly recorded peak waiting times of up to 120 minutes. Average passport control waits over the past three weeks, however, were far lower, at 12 to 14 minutes in Amsterdam and six to seven minutes in Frankfurt, according to data from line-monitoring platform Qsensor.

"The situation remains manageable in France given the option taken by the French authorities to prioritize fluidity for airline passengers at airports," said Laurent Timsit, managing director of the French Aviation Industry Federation. "The waiting times at the border may accordingly be long at certain times but this is not necessarily the consequence of EES. It may also be related to staffing or IT issues," Timsit told Tommaso.

Missing technology: According to Timsit, the biggest challenge in France is "the absence of a functioning kiosk system" that would allow passengers to upload their biometric data themselves. "As long as this is not solved, the French authorities do need to resort to the existing flexibilities enshrined in the EU regulation," he added.

"Our main worry is that these flexibilities will come to an end after Sept. 6," Timsit said, warning that without an extension "French authorities will be unable to guarantee fluidity at border control."

LOGISTICS

SHIPPING COSTS SURGE WITH LOW WATER LEVELS: The low water levels in the Rhine and other waterways are developing into a massive headache for businesses, with retailers reporting that shipping costs are up 400 percent or more, our colleague Frida Preuß reports.

One of the many bottlenecks: On the route between the ports of Gelsenkirchen and Antwerp, ships can currently only operate at 25 percent of their normal cargo capacity because of the low water levels, said Antonin Finkelnburg, CEO of the Federation of German Wholesale, Foreign Trade and Services. Shipping costs have quadrupled, he added.

Lacking other options: Some companies have shifted to rail or freight, also pushing up those rates. And rail cannot absorb all of the excess volume due to its own lack of capacity and delays, Finkelnburg said. "When in doubt, goods will be transported by truck if possible."

The catch: Specialized trucks for bulk goods, such as silo and tank trucks, are only available in limited quantities, said Frank Huster, CEO of the German Freight Forwarding and Logistics Association. And the sector has a shortage of drivers. The shift to road transport is subject to “strict limitations.”

A drop in the ocean: Some German states have temporarily lifted restrictions that banned trucks from driving on Sundays, but Huster warns that the decisions will “hardly create any additional cargo space.”

A silver lining: The shift in transport methods should shorten arrival times for goods, Huster said, adding that while “fewer goods can be transported, they are significantly faster by rail and road than by inland waterway.”

HORMUZ HYPE: U.S. Energy Secretary Chris Wright says about 9 million barrels of oil are moving through the Strait of Hormuz every day. But nonpartisan oil tanker trackers say it’s likely 7 million barrels at best, or more likely, closer to 5 million. More here from Scott Waldman.

PIT STOPS

From us: European air traffic delays dropped sharply this summer compared with last year, but airlines say that’s still nowhere near enough as looming problems in France worry the industry.

From us: British rail operator Virgin Trains has received pre-approval to run international train services through the Channel Tunnel, potentially breaking the current monopoly held by Eurostar.

Headlines

Here’s a recap of yesterday’s news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

Trump’s rosy Hormuz claims collide with tanker data

The Trump administration has said the Strait of Hormuz is open for business and oil is flowing. Market trackers suggest a less rosy picture.

By Scott Waldman · Aug 17, 2026, 09:52 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

European subsidies fuel China’s EV export boom

There is growing political pressure to rethink subsidy programs for electric cars thanks to the fast rise in Chinese EV sales.

By Jordyn Dahl, Thorsten Mumme · Aug 17, 2026, 05:07 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

Europe cuts flight delays, but France remains the weak link

Despite handling more flights, controllers managed to slash delays by more than 20 percent.

By Tommaso Lecca · Aug 17, 2026, 04:50 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

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